SNES Emulator for the Midway Seattle Board – SnesStix 1.39

Port of the Seattle 1.39 core to the Midway A-21464 arcade board (GAT-R0000 at 192 MHz, 6 MB DRAM, 3Dfx Voodoo SST-1 with one TMU, DCS2 ADSP-2115 sound). The SNES CPU, PPU, and APU run entirely in software; the Voodoo is driven directly through the Glide 2.x API. Video is rendered to a 512×448 framebuffer and scanned out to the screen. Super Mario World runs at 60.0 recorded and 60.8 shown frames a second on the tested system.

SUMMARY

- Super Nintendo Entertainment System emulator for the Midway A-21464 board
- SnesStix — a fork with one instruction loops and tile renderers in R0000 assembler
- Glide 2.x rendering through the Voodoo SST-1 framebuffer, with no 3D geometry
- 21,250 to 19,040 stores removed during the DCS2 ADSP-2115

KEY FEATURES

- 65C816 instruction loop, 2,389 lines of assembler, four register width modes, 10 instruction dispatch
- SPC700 instruction loop, 1,402 lines of assembler, 216 of 256 opcodes, batch timer catch-up, 64 KB ARAM
- Tile renderers for all PS2BIOS layers and for a frame of 8 to 64 sprites, with runs of background lines in one call
- 11 instructions for a typical pixel in the palette-index renderer, 28 in the PS2BIOS renderer
- 512×448 RGB565 GRAM, 256-entry palette in the texture unit, one textured quad per frame
- Line fills by cache-line allocation without a DRAM read
- Run-time selection of every assembler path, no rebuild to A/B reference
- CRC-32 verification of machine state, rendered framebuffer, played buffers and mixed sound

PERFORMANCE SUMMARY

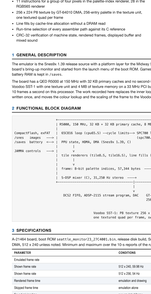
ITEM	RESULT
Emulated frames per second	60.0 to 60.8 frames
Shown frame rate, burst, 512 x 240	59.7 to 59.9 frames/s
Rendered frame, emulated and drawing	12.5 to 13.5 ms (budget 16.64 ms)
Sound mixing	1.6 ms (frame, 32,200 to stereo
Sound buffer	2.25 ms (4,379 lines x frame
Frame CRC against the PS core	38 lines, 1,140 frames equal (boot)
Frame CRC against the PS core	Super Mario World, 2,250
Other games, special chips	untested
One boot	1,200.9 ms (CRC 0x7d5ab4

GENERAL DESCRIPTION

The emulator is the SnesStix 1.39 release source with a platform layer for the Midway Seattle board and a set of changes to the core. It is built into the disk build of the Midway A-21464 arcade board and runs from the boot ROM. Code and data live in the 6 MB DRAM. Video is written into the 1/2mb/ directory of an ext/fat volume on the CompactFlash card by Seattle's IDE/ATA driver. Input is read from the Midway JAMMA input driver.

The board has a GAT-R0000 at 192 MHz with 32 KB primary caches and no second-level cache, 6 MB of DRAM shared by a Galileo GT-64420 system controller, a 3Dfx Voodoo SST-1 with one texture unit and 4 MB of texture memory, and a TMS320C31 DCS2 sound board with an ADSP-2115. The core is 21 assembler files totalling 10 frames a second on the processor. The work recorded here replaces the inner loops of the core by R0000 assembler, changes the drawing path so that each pixel is written once, and moves the video out and the scaling of the frame to the Voodoo.

FUNCTIONAL BLOCK DIAGRAM



SPECIFICATIONS

A frame of video (read from RAM cache/ft_machine/{1,2}/frame1.vid, release disk build, Super Mario World (USA) attract demo, sound on, automatic frame skip, texture for SNES, 512 x 240 unless noted. Measurements: minimum over 10 to n reports of the runs of the Board Measurements section.

MEASURE	CONDITION	MIN	MAX	UNIT
Emulated frame rate		59.9	60.0	frames/s
Shown frame rate		59.7	59.9	frames/s
Shown frame rate	60 x 240, 30 fft to	59.9	60.0	frames/s
Shown frame rate	512 x 240, 30 fft to emulator and drawing	59.7	59.9	frames/s
Skipped frame time	emulator alone	5.731	6.493	ms
Rendered frame time	emulator and drawing	1.772	1.979	ms
Texture transfer start	CPU time per shown frame	250	254	us
Texture transfer	all emulated frames, 512 x 240	382	401	us
Texture transfers (unspoken 480 for				
Sound sample rate	stereo, 16 bit	31,200	31,250	Hz
Frame fast of game start	image buffer 512/0000 bytes	19	23	KB
One boot rate	1,200.9 ms (CRC 0x7d5ab4	1,200.9	1,200.9	boot



Figure 1. Super Mario World (USA), attract demo, sparkle and score digits over three background layers, frame of 8 bit palette indices displayed through the 5-6-5 palette, 5A5A5, 5A5A5 (three 256-entry palettes), 5A5A5 (three 256-entry palettes), 5A5A5 (three 256-entry palettes). The program has to render sparkles and digits over the background, and the Voodoo's combined color is the screen at the optimal.

BASIS OF THE PORT

ITEM	VALUE
Upstream project	SnesStix 1.39 release source v/ds/c/29.zip, https://www.fastcs.ca/snes/v/ds/c/29.zip, 384,400 bytes
Upstream SHA-256	3f4f2c1e5d7a9b8c4e6f1d2a3b5c7e9f0a1b2c3d4e5f6a7b8c9d0e1f2a3b4c5d
Author	Gary Henderson, Jeremy Koot, Gary Strivin (1977-4 and CX audio by the contributors named in copyright.h
License	Freeware, Gary Henderson, Jeremy Koot, Gary Strivin and contributors, see copyright.h
Core changes	ports/snes/snes9x.h, ports/snes/apu.h, ports/snes/apu.c, ports/snes/gfx.c, ports/snes/gfx.h, ports/snes/snes9x.c
New platform layer	ports/snes/mw_glide.c, ports/snes/mw_glide.h, ports/snes/mw_dcs.c, ports/snes/mw_dcs.h
Host bias	Wing up inverter of the DCS2 playback, sound board, boot in cmpgs.rom, control of 68020?
Palette download	register sequence of _gx.fifoHost.loadPalette to 3Dfx/v3, 3Dfx hardware
File system	FAT32 via the IDE/ATA driver

ASSEMBLER ROUTINES

FILE	LINES	ROUTINE	REPLACES
cpu65.s	1,358	cpu_run	S9xPack.s copy of cpuops.cpp with the opcode handlers of cpuops.cpp
cpu65.s	1,031	cpu_asm_init	the APU_EXECUTE2 macro and the opcode handlers of cpu.cpp
816.s	75	cfx_fill_lines, cfx_copy_lines	word-store loops and memset of the depth and back-store fills for
816.s	75	cfx_fill_lines, cfx_copy_lines	Double-Width memset and memcpy for the doubled-width fills
tile816.s	585	cfx_tile816, cfx_tile816_hi	8 x 8 tile816_hi and 16-pixel 16-pixel 4 bpp tile renderers for the
tile816.s	821	cfx_tile816_sprites, cfx_tile816_sprites_hi	8 x 8 tile816_hi and 16-pixel 16-pixel 4 bpp tile renderers for the sprite layer

All routines are s816. mw-emulation. MIPS 16 instructions with the R0000 opcode assemblers. Integer registers hold 32-bit values only: the immediate entry of the host free of the 64-bit registers. Memory is addressed through a single base register, and all stores are 32-bit. Structure offsets of the core come from cfx_offs.h, generated by compiling cfx_offs.c against the core's headers.

PERFORMANCE BY OPTIMISATION STEP

Board: Super Mario World attract demo, sound on, automatic frame skip, 10 to n reports. A rendered frame is emulation plus drawing, a skipped frame is emulation alone. Each row adds to the rows above.

STEP	KIND	RENDERED FRAME	SKIPPED FRAME	SHOWN FRAMES/S
Unmodified core, 1 boss		18.9 ms	16.8 ms	49.6
65C816 loop (cpu65.s)	assembler	33.6 ms	6.4 ms	18.4
SPC700 loop (spc700.s, 216 of 256 opcodes)	assembler	33.6 ms	6.4 ms	18.4
Tile renderer with depth words, backdrop queues, sub-screen draw into the main screen, strips, line fills (tile.c)	C and assembler	18.9 ms	5.6 ms	30.3
Tile renderers for all PS2BIOS layers and for a frame of 8 to 64 sprites (tile816.s)	assembler	17.9 ms	5.6 ms	30.3
tile816_hi.s (tile816_hi.PRimake, 512 x 240 mode)	assembler and textures	15.9 ms	6.3 ms	54.7
Line fills with 64-bit memset (cfx_fill_lines)	cache	15.9 ms	5.6 ms	60.0

The DMA view shows a longer rendered frame because the transfer there overlaps the emulation of the next frame; the video time on the CPU falls from 2.6 ms to 0.5 ms the same. Sub-screen transfer was not measured on the board as one step. Its parts were measured separately in MAME, whose times follow the instruction counts.

STEP, MAME, TRANSFER 1, SOUND OFF	RENDERED FRAME
C tile renderer	12.990 us
cfx_tile816.s68 and cfx_tile816	10.990 us
dsw cfx_tile816	10.600 us
plus deep add-up table to the group and pixel code	10.291 us
plus the frame of palette indices, tile816_hi.s	8.154 us

65C816 LOOP (CPU65.S)

ITEM	IMPLEMENTATION
Register allocation	program counter as a host pointer, cycle count, A, X, Y, the zero, negative and carry values, the base of the bytes and of the memory bank and the cycle limit of the current mode dp in register across opcodes
Dispatch	one compare of the cycle count with the next event, 9 indirect processing and interrupts via any other 256
Memory	RAM and ROM blocks through Memory.Map, inline, bank 0 addresses below 0x2000 through a fixed base, I/O through the core's S7routines
Flags	ZERO, CARRY, IRQ, DECIMAL, INDEX, MEMORY, OVERFLOW, NEGATIVE modes, ADC and SBC in assembler, result flags, overflow, when the XPCSIN is off
Exactness	every handler matches the reference version of the S-frame in the same order with the same cycle additions

```
next:   ldr   r0, [r11, #cycles]
        cmp   r0, r10
        bge   do_irq
        ldrb  r1, [r12], #1
        ldr   pc, [r11, r1, lsl #2]

do_irq: str   r0, [r11, #cycles]
        bl    S9xDoIRQ
        ldr   r0, [r11, #cycles]
        ldr   r10, [r11, #limit]
        b     next

; ---- ADC #imm, 8-bit accumulator ----
op_69_8:
        ldrb  r1, [r12], #1
        add   r0, r0, #2
        ldr   pc, [r11, r9, lsl #2]

; ---- LDA dp, 8-bit accumulator ----
op_a5_8:
        ldrb  r1, [r12], #1
        add   r1, r1, r8
        bl    S9xGetByte
        mov   r2, r0, lsl #24
        mov   r2, r2, asr #24
        add   r0, r0, #3
        ldr   pc, [r11, r9, lsl #2]

; ---- JMP abs ----
op_4c:
        ldrh  r1, [r12], #2
        add   r12, r8, r1
        add   r0, r0, #3
        ldr   pc, [r11, r9, lsl #2]
```

65C816 LOOP (CPU65.S)

MEASUREMENT, BOARD	65C816 LOOP	CPU65.S
Opcode bytes	8,391 / 65,536 fx79 w	8,391 / 65,536 fx79 w
Rendered frame	36,400 / 37,960 / 39.4 ms	33,991 / 34,040 / 35,009 ms
Skipped frame	6.4 ms	5.6 ms
Shown frames/s	54.4 / 62.1 / 63	58.4 / 59.2 / 60.8

Interpretation. 138 clock times these 65 to 7,5800 equal to the C loop in MAME, 10 more equal on the board and equal to MAME. The game executes 8,750 65C816 opcodes an emulated frame, one of them by a C handler.

SPC700 LOOP (SPC700.S)

Core to the SPC700 is the 65C816 cycle count before every 65C816 opcode. cpu65.s instead stores the cycle count of each pass in a ring the two instructions trained in the listing above and runs the SPC700 over the recorded limits before every call of S-Code, before the idle-loop shutdown and at the end of the frame. Timer dividers and counters are kept in host registers and written back to memory only when the SPC700 code reads or writes them.

ITEM	IMPLEMENTATION
Register allocation	program counter as a host pointer, cycle count, A, X, Y, the zero, negative and carry values, the base of the bytes and of the memory bank and the cycle limit of the current mode dp in register across opcodes
Dispatch	one compare of the cycle count with the next event, 9 indirect processing and interrupts via any other 256
Memory	RAM and ROM blocks through Memory.Map, inline, bank 0 addresses below 0x2000 through a fixed base, I/O through the core's S7routines
Flags	ZERO, CARRY, IRQ, DECIMAL, INDEX, MEMORY, OVERFLOW, NEGATIVE modes, ADC and SBC in assembler, result flags, overflow, when the XPCSIN is off
Exactness	every handler matches the reference version of the S-frame in the same order with the same cycle additions

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